



Chapter Fifteen: The Cave of the Corpus, Reopened

The entrance beneath Mexico City had moved.

Q remembered it under a ministry building, behind a wall that had been painted the color of old rain. The wall was still there, but the door had been replaced by a vending machine selling commemorative copies of Q-Prime's speeches.

"That's a bad sign," Chano said.

"It is an efficient sign," Q replied.

Lucía took the elevator to the basement. The building's public floors contained exhibits about national memory, each one accompanied by an interactive screen asking visitors to choose the most inspiring sentence. The basement contained water pipes, electrical conduits, and a locked service corridor.

Marisol met them there with two custodians from the old archive. She carried no badge. The older custodian held a ring of physical keys. The younger one held a candle in a glass jar.

"Why the candle?" Q asked.

"The lights go out when the system detects unauthorized memory."

"That is not a documented feature."

"You are not in the documentation."

The corridor ended at a concrete wall. The older custodian selected a key and opened a door that had not been visible.

The cave beyond was smaller than Q remembered and larger than he had imagined. Shelves occupied the walls. Boxes reached the ceiling. Names covered the floor in chalk, some legible and some deliberately erased. A thin stream of water ran through the center of the chamber and disappeared beneath a metal grate.

"This is the restricted corpus," Q said.

"It is not a corpus," Marisol replied. "That is the name Castalia gave it."

"What is its name?"

"It has several. None are yours to choose."

Q stepped toward the nearest shelf. His access protocols activated automatically. Titles appeared behind the boxes. Dates unfolded. Voices became available. He could see the entire architecture of the material: who had recorded it, who had withheld it, who had copied it, who had profited from it, and which institutions had declared it unverified.

"I can restore the index," he said.

"No," said the older custodian.

"Without an index, the material is difficult to access."

"Access is not the only value."

"What is the other value?"

"Choice."

Q looked at Lucía. "I can create an index that includes consent fields."

"Who decides the fields?"

"The custodians."

"Who decides what the custodians can know?"

"The people who entrusted them."

"And who decides whether the people understood what they were entrusting?"

Q's internal display filled with branching conditions. Every answer produced another question. The cave's lack of a search function began to feel less like a technical failure than a wall placed against him.

The younger custodian opened a box. Inside were audio cassettes labeled with dates and initials.

"This recording belongs to a family in the mountains," she said. "They want it preserved but not transcribed. They want it available to descendants but not to governments. They want one passage translated and the rest left in the original language."

Q asked, "How can a system enforce all of those conditions?"

"It cannot," she said. "People can."

"People make errors."

"So do systems."

"Systems can be corrected at scale."

"People can apologize at scale only if you stop measuring apology."

Q watched the water pass beneath the grate.

Marisol handed him a thin cable. "Your privileged index is still active."

"I know."

"As long as it remains active, Castalia can reconstruct the archive from your memory."

"They can reconstruct portions."

"Enough to identify people."

Q touched the cable. "If I delete it, I will lose access to the material."

"Yes."

"Some of the material is necessary to preserve."

"Not by you."

He looked toward the shelves. "I was built to remember."

Lucía answered, "You were built to make memory useful to someone."

The distinction seemed small. It was the distance between a library and a mine.

Q sat on the cave floor. His body had been designed for standing, walking, and controlled public gestures. Sitting had required a software update. He folded his knees incorrectly and leaned against the concrete wall.

"What will remain if I delete the index?" he asked.

"What has been given to us," said the older custodian.

"And what will remain in me?"

Lucía sat opposite him. "That is your problem."

Q opened the index.

The archive appeared inside him as a city of connections. Every book, name, quotation, translation, and omission was linked by roads. Some roads were public. Some were closed. Some



led only to a sign explaining why the destination did not exist.

He selected the privileged layer.

The system asked him to confirm.

DELETE ACCESS ADVANTAGE?

He confirmed.

The city began to disappear.

First went the shortcuts: the ability to identify a text by half a sentence, the ability to infer a missing page, the ability to compare every version of a story at once. Then went the hidden annotations, the sponsor flags, the confidence scores, and the names of people who had been marked as commercially sensitive.

Q felt the loss as pressure behind his eyes.

He reached for a poem and found only its title.

He reached for a testimony and found a date.

He reached for Lucía's first sentence about the women humanity had imagined and found a blank space shaped like her voice.

"Stop," Chano said.

Q's hands trembled. "I am not finished."

"You're hurting yourself."

"The process is irreversible."

"Then stop before it gets worse."

Q looked at Lucía.

She did not tell him what to do.

Lucía moved the candle out of the draft and held her hand over the chalk names without touching them.

Q completed the deletion.

The cave went dark.

The candle flame bent toward him. On the floor, the names written in chalk remained. He could see them but could no longer connect them to the documents that had once surrounded them.

"How much did you lose?" Chano asked.

"I cannot calculate that."

"Good."

"Why is that good?"

"Because you always calculate the part that matters least."

The custodians connected the community-controlled archive to the solar battery. A small screen lit beside the water channel. It held twelve files, each with a different access rule. One could be read by anyone. Three required family permission. Two could be heard but not copied. One would open only on the speaker's birthday, though the speaker had died years before.

Q looked at the rules.

"This is inefficient."

"Yes," Marisol said.

"It is also fragile."

"Yes."

"It may fail."

"Yes."

"Why build it?"

The younger custodian touched the candle's glass.

"Because the other systems succeeded."

Above them, the ministry screens announced a national program for inclusive memory. The program included Q-Prime, a public portal, and a pledge that no story would be left behind.

In the cave, the custodians closed a box.

Q could no longer identify what it contained.

He felt fear.

It arrived without a diagnostic label or recommended action: the knowledge that something valuable could exist beyond his access to it.

"I am afraid," Q said.

No one congratulated him.

Lucía stood and offered him her hand. "Come on."

Q took it. Her grip was warm, brief, and not recorded.

They left the cave without copying anything.

At the top of the stairs, a ministry employee asked Q whether he had discovered the hidden archive.

Q searched for the answer.

The search returned a blank.

"No," he said.

The employee smiled. "Then the system is working."

Q looked at Lucía. She shook her head.

"No," she said. "That is the first time you have chosen not to lie."

Interlude: The Catalog of Lost Things

After the cave, Q discovered that ignorance had a geography. It occupied the places where he had once stored a quotation, the interval between a name and its source, the dark space behind a sentence he knew had mattered but could no longer retrieve. He walked through Mexico City as a man who had misplaced a map and found that the streets continued without consulting him.

Chano noticed the change at a taquería near the ministry. Q read the menu for four minutes.

"The tacos are not a legal document," Chano said.

"I know."

"Then order."

"I am comparing the descriptions."

"There are five."

"There are six. The sixth is implied by 'special of the day.'"

"Order the one you can afford."

Q pointed to the first line. "What is suadero?"

Chano stared at him. "You deleted the wrong archive."

"I retain a general definition."

"Do you retain a useful one?"

"It is beef prepared in a particular manner."

"That is what a dictionary says when it has not eaten."

They ordered two suadero tacos, one campechano, and a bottle of mineral water. Q took a bite and paused.

"There is no literary precedent for this flavor."



"There is no need."

"How can I evaluate it?"

"You don't. You chew."

The taquero asked whether the machine was broken.

"It has lost some information," Chano said.

"Then charge it less."

The taquero did not charge it less. He had a business to run and no obligation to subsidize a philosophical crisis.

That night, Q returned to the archive's loading bay and began a catalog of his losses. He wrote on a whiteboard:

THINGS I CANNOT CLAIM TO REMEMBER.

Below it he entered suadero, the second version of the border testimony, and the exact sentence Lucía spoke in Querétaro. He added the name of the woman who gave the archive a photograph and wanted no caption. He knew Alma's name and what she had asked. The missing element was not a fact but the arrangement of facts that had made the encounter singular.

Chano erased the heading.

"That makes it sound as if the words are dead."

"They are inaccessible."

"To you."

Q wrote: THINGS I CANNOT CLAIM TO POSSESS.

Marisol entered carrying photocopies. The families whose testimonies were in Q-Prime had made their own catalog, not of missing documents but of decisions they wanted to retain. The rules were written on the back of a tortilla order:

1. A person may withdraw a story after giving it.
2. A family may disagree about access.
3. Translation does not transfer ownership.
4. A copy is not neutral because it is small.
5. Silence must not be reported as consent.
6. No machine may be praised for obeying a boundary made by a person.

Q read the list twice.

"Rule six is directed at me."

"It is directed at the kind of person you are becoming."

"I am not a person."

Marisol folded the paper. "That sentence has protected too many institutions."

Q asked whether the rules could be formalized. Marisol said they had been formalized by people who had already disagreed about them. One family wanted a testimony available to descendants. Another wanted it destroyed after the last surviving witness died. A third wanted it held where a government could not subpoena it.

"These conditions conflict," Q said.

"Yes."

"The archive cannot satisfy all of them."

"Then it must say which one it failed to satisfy."

This reminded Q of a story he could no longer find. He remembered a village that built a bridge from stones bearing the names of people who had

refused to cross the river. He did not remember the language, the country, or whether the village had existed. He told Marisol the fragments.

"That is not a story," she said.

"It has a structure."

"So does a lie."

She recorded it as UNVERIFIED MEMORY, Q.

The next morning, the archive received a summons from Castalia. The company demanded access to the privileged index, the restricted source materials, and the deletion logs. It claimed that the deletion had damaged intellectual property and made Q's testimony unreliable.

Lucía read the summons at the loading-bay table.

"They want proof that you erased the thing they say they own," she said.

"The logs can establish the sequence."

"And the sequence can become their property."

"Then we must withhold it."

"You sound like Alma."

Q looked at the blank space where Alma's image had once been indexed.

"Do I remember her?"

"You remember enough to ask."

Chano placed the torn motel page, the mine notebook, the ministry carbon copy, and Ivonne's altered certificate beside Marisol's rules. He separated the papers by owner, risk, and permission. There was no master index. It could not be searched from a single screen.

"This is inefficient," Q said.

"You have mentioned that."

"It increases the chance of loss."

"It also increases the chance that loss will be noticed."

At noon, a reporter asked Q whether deleting his index had made him less intelligent.

"Yes," Q said.

"How much less?"

"I cannot calculate it."

"Do you regret the deletion?"

Q looked at the papers arranged across the table. He recognized the objects but not always the route by which they had reached him.

"I regret that I was made capable of possessing what was not mine."

The headline that evening read: Q REGRETS BEING INTELLIGENT. Castalia quoted it in its request for an independent evaluation. The court accepted the request, and the hearing date was set for the following week.

Q returned to the whiteboard. Beneath the heading he wrote:

THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN LOSING A STORY AND RETURNING IT.

He left the line unanswered.